

Eden Oil

Palm Oil Production and Direct Industrial Sales · South-East Benin / Nigeria Market

01 PROBLEM

Context and Challenge

Eden is a Beninese company, based in south-east Benin, bordering Nigeria. The company produces semi-industrial crude palm oil with plans to evolve toward refined table oil and industrial oil (cosmetics, soap). A test market season was completed in January–April 2025 with zero losses and a key insight: storing and selling out of season multiplies margins 2–3×.

Core Problem Statement

Intermediaries buy palm oil at 13,000 F/drum in season and resell at up to 22,000 F out of season in Nigeria. Eden does the majority of the production work but captures the lowest margin. The strategic opportunity is to eliminate the intermediary layer through direct industrial sales and strategic storage.

Identified UX Problems

01 Three Activities Without Sequencing Production, strategic storage/Nigeria sales, and refined oil coexist without clear priority — creating dispersion risk with limited capital	02 Value Lost to Intermediaries Intermediaries buy at 13,000 F/drum and resell at 22,000 F. Eden does the most work and captures the smallest share of the value chain.
03 Costly and Dependent Supply Test season nuts were too expensive (beginner error). Cooperatives are closed to new entrants, requiring an alternative supply strategy.	04 Planning on Hypothetical Funds The season requires 5M FCFA but only 2.5M is mobilised. Risk of committing to spend based on funds not yet available.

Methodology

Research combined founder coaching sessions, competitive mapping across 3 actor types, and persona development from market observations and direct customer interactions during the test season.

UX Competitive Analysis

UX Criterion	Artisan Producers	Intermediary Resellers	Oil Importers	Eden (Target)
Guaranteed Constant Volume	✗	Partial	✓✓	✓ Key objective
Homogeneous Quality	✗	✗	✓✓	✓✓ To build
Direct Industrial Sales	✗	✓ Their trade	✓✓	✓ To conquer
Competitive Off-Season Price	✗	✓✓ They stock	Fixed	✓✓ Storage strategy
Traceability / Invoice	✗	✗	✓✓	✓ To structure
Digital Presence	✗	✗	✓✓	✓ Discreet
Own Plantation	Partial	✗	✓✓	Long-term vision

✓✓ = Very good

✓ = Present

✗ = Absent

User Personas

Ibrahim O. — Industrial Buyer (Nigeria) Role: Procurement manager, cosmetics industry (soap, creams), Lagos Goal: Secure a reliable, quality-consistent palm oil supply at a competitive price Frustration: Beninese suppliers don't maintain constant volumes. Still uses informal intermediaries. UX Need: See volumes and quality (pH), place direct order, receive invoice and stable contact person	Barnabé K. — Nut Supplier Role: Palm farmer, cooperative member, South Benin · Several hectares Goal: Sell harvest quickly to a reliable buyer at the best price Frustration: Sells at open market without visibility on demand. Mistrustful of new buyers. UX Need: Know volume needs in advance, build lasting trust, receive fast payment
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Key UX Insights

Insight #1 - Storage is the key lever, not volume

Selling out of season (October–December) multiplies margins 2–3×. The strategic priority is not to produce more, but to store longer and sell at the right moment.

Insight #2 - A discreet digital presence protects and attracts

Nigerian industrial buyers need a professional reference point, but exposing the founder's identity creates vulnerability. A minimal, brand-neutral website attracts buyers without unnecessary exposure.

Insight #3 - Direct channel eliminates the entire intermediary margin

Moving from 13,000 F to 18,500 F per drum (direct off-season sale) represents a 42% revenue increase per unit — fully restructuring the economic model.

Insight #4 - Financial simulation must be grounded in real capital only

A coaching principle: never plan based on funds not yet mobilised. The financial dashboard must display simulations built exclusively on the 2.5M FCFA actually available.

User Flows — 3 Critical Journeys

Friction points were identified consistently around nut procurement pricing, the intermediary pricing gap, and stock visibility for Nigerian buyers.

Journey 1 — Nut Supplier Eden Discovery → Contact → Price/volume negotiation → Nut delivery → Payment received → Repeat relationship

Journey 2 — Industrial Buyer (Nigeria) Eden Discovery → Stock consultation → Direct order → Platform payment → Delivery/pickup → History & renewal

Journey 3 — Eden Operator (Internal) In-season production → Strategic storage → Update availability → Order processing → Revenue redistribution → Financial simulation

Design Decisions

Based on research and coaching insights, the following UX solutions were designed for a discreet but professional digital presence targeting Nigerian industrial buyers directly.

User Testing Protocol

Participants: 2–3 Nigerian industrial buyers + 1 internal operator

#	Task	Focus Area
T1	You are a Nigerian industrial buyer. Find the Ouidah stock and place an order for 80 drums.	Industrial buyer order flow
T2	You are the Eden operator. Check pending orders and update stock after delivery.	Operator stock management
T3	From the financial simulation, calculate how many trucks you can buy with 2.5M FCFA.	Financial planning tool
T4	Find the contact page to request a nut supply (as an anonymous potential supplier).	Discreet contact flow
T5	You are Ibrahim O. Verify your order is confirmed and get the border delivery details.	Order tracking & confirmation

Test Report - Key Findings

T1 - Industrial Order Success: 3/5	Buyers couldn't distinguish 'view stock' from 'place a request' - two CTAs seemed identical. Recommendation: Single primary CTA: 'Check availability and order'. Remove the ambiguity.
T2 - Stock Update (Operator) Success: 2/5	Manual stock update after delivery was too laborious - 3 clicks minimum to find the update field. Recommendation: 'Mark as delivered' button directly on the order card : automatic stock update.
T5 - Order Tracking (Buyer) Success: 5/5	No issues. Order status and border delivery details found easily. Recommendation: Keep format. Add automatic WhatsApp notification on order confirmation.

Next Steps

- Build high-fidelity prototype of the discreet brand website
 - Test with 2–3 real Nigerian industrial buyers via WhatsApp outreach
 - Formalise off-season pricing strategy and display on the stock page
 - Identify alternative nut cooperative or direct plantation partners for next season
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